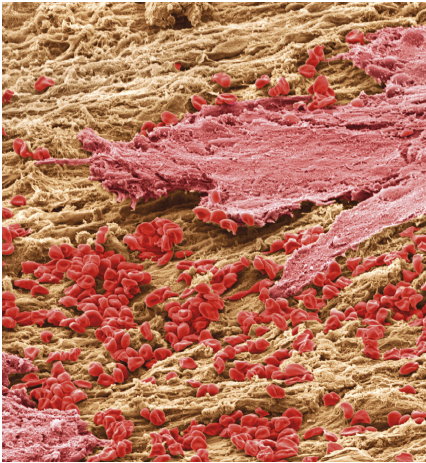




THIS IS **DAY 3 OF YOUR MENSTRUAL CYCLE**
277 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

The lining of the uterus, known as the endometrium, can be seen here (pink structure) shedding during menstruation. This happens if a fertilized egg does not implant. The red dots are red blood cells, released when the blood vessels break down.

“When you’re trying to get pregnant, it helps to be aware of lifestyle and medical factors that can affect your menstrual cycle.”

You may notice the timing, frequency, and volume of your period differs. Your menstrual cycle can be affected by stress as well as by medical conditions, such as an overactive thyroid. In both these cases, periods can become lighter or less frequent. If your periods are erratic, it can be difficult to predict when you might ovulate. Irregular or missed periods may mean that ovulation isn't occurring at all, such as in polycystic ovary syndrome. If you know this is the case because you're monitoring your ovulation or using predictor tests (see [Changes during the menstrual cycle](#)), seek medical advice.

You may be able to become pregnant naturally and easily despite problems related to your period, but some conditions that cause long, irregular, or heavy periods are linked to lower fertility. Heavy periods can be caused by conditions such as fibroids (see [Fibroids during Pregnancy](#)), which can affect fertility. A higher than average level of blood loss can also make you anemic, which is not the best start for pregnancy for you or your baby, so you may want to look at boosting your iron intake (see [Iron-rich foods](#)).

Painful periods can affect fertility. Endometriosis is a common disorder that can make periods painful and cause discomfort during sex. If you have these symptoms, you may be referred to a specialist. In endometriosis, cells resembling those that line the uterus come to lie outside the uterus on structures such as the ovaries, fallopian tubes, and walls of the pelvis. This condition can sometimes be treated by surgery, especially severe cases, which may boost a woman's chance of conceiving.

STIMULATING EGG FOLLICLES

IVF (in vitro fertilization) may be an option if you are having trouble conceiving. The first stage with this procedure is to stimulate the ovaries to produce several follicles, so that multiple eggs can be fertilized outside the body. Starting on around day two of your cycle, you will be given drugs to stimulate your ovaries. You will need to inject yourself or sometimes use a nasal spray to